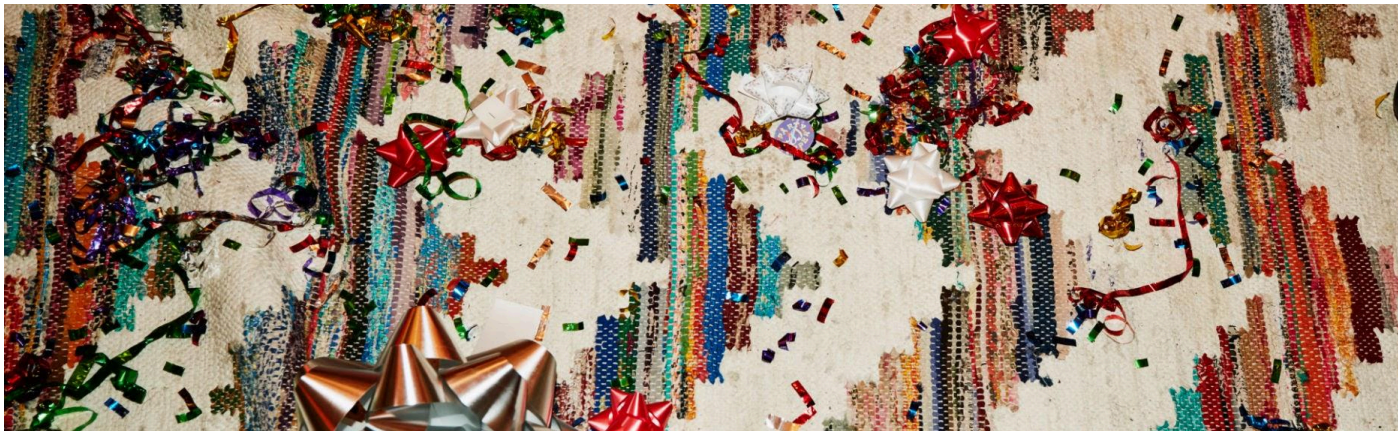

# NEIGHBORHOODS OF THE FUTURE

CONCEPT NOTE - Draft for Discussion

## It Takes a Village (Neighbourhood)

Urban challenges are complex, interconnected, and deeply tied to place. Whether it's climate stress, weak civic infrastructure, fragmented service delivery, or rising social isolation — these are not problems that can be solved by a single program, actor, or policy. They show up together, and they require responses that are just as interconnected.

Yet too often, development in cities is approached as a delivery exercise — interventions brought in from outside, defined by efficiency and scale, and disconnected from the people and places they are meant to serve. Even strong programs struggle to scale when they are locked within institutional silos, fixed geographies, or rigid operating models.

What we need is not just new solutions, but a different way of working together — one that centres place, builds on existing efforts, and allows for ongoing adaptation.

*One that treats neighborhoods as active ecosystems of experience, knowledge, and possibility.*

Neighborhoods of the Future (NoF) is an effort to support this shift. There are many innovative practices that speak to our shared values- ecology, local economy, devolved decision-making, distributed wisdom, etc. These practices are currently distributed across multiple organisations and locations.

How do we make practices that work in one place easier to adapt and apply elsewhere? We imagine something as practical and accessible as UPI or a QR code — simple, universal, and built for everyday use.

# Introducing Neighborhoods of the Future (NoF)

Neighborhoods of the Future (NoF) is based on the assumption that ideas for local action exist and when communities access and adapt these ideas, the neighbourhoods are oriented towards a self directed and responsive future. NoF is imagined as an evolving place-based platform that supports such collaboration across actors working in the same geography, in parallel.

It recognises that neighbourhoods already hold many efforts -but that these are often disconnected, invisible to one another, or constrained by institutional boundaries. NoF helps reduce that friction.

Over time, NoF aims to bring together

a. community initiatives and organisations (CBOs)- anchored in a specific location, with relationships, local knowledge, and staying power with

b. ideas anchored by individuals and institutions in relevant

*domains*- like water, livelihoods, education, biodiversity... and

*functions*- design, place making, resourcing, communication,...

It is seen as an approach to synchronize and converge, if needed, local efforts to enable ground-up change and devolved decision making.

At this stage we're creating a shared canvas- one that allows different actors to enter with what they already know, already do, and already care about-while making it easier to align, adapt, and add to one another's work.

## Building a Shared Canvas of Action

Over time, the aim is to grow the number and types of members in the initiative- local organisations, civic groups, thematic experts, public institutions and market players- who have a stake in the long-term, place-based improvement.

The services and infrastructure offered by the platform will be curated by the community members' understanding of local aspirations, constraints, and cultural patterns. Rather than applying one-size-fits-all solutions, this approach ensures that interventions respond to what people already value, struggle with, and hope for- enabling more meaningful, coherent, and place-specific transformation.

## “Swarm” the System

When multiple actors show up in the same geography- each from a different entry point but working with aligned purpose- we become a swarm of change and possibility- harder to be ignored. The energy compounds. Communities begin to see possibility, not as isolated events, but as a pattern. Local institutions start to take notice. Systems that were once resistant to change become more porous.

That’s how we become viral: when formats start to travel and models become legible to others- not because they were replicated or branded, but because they were seen in action by many, at once.

That’s the “Why” and “What”. Here's the “How”.

# How will NoF Work?

NoF supports practical collaboration across actors. It helps identify overlaps, reduce duplication, and accelerate cross pollination. It acts as a facilitator and librarian-not a gatekeeper.

It provides:

- Directory and Atlas: Mapping who is working where, and on what. What are their parameters of work-scale, geography, domain?
- Intermediary support: Helping organisations identify potential partners, align offers and asks, and adapt their work to local contexts.
- Monthly cadence calls and Quarterly in-person convenings: Rotational conversations across partners to surface needs, share learning, and reflect on emerging patterns.
- Playbooks and toolkits: Resources and documentation to support adaptation, not just adoption. What has worked elsewhere and why? What was the method?
- Marketplace of offerings**:** A space where physical, financial, knowledge-based, and social resources are pooled and shared *transparently*-small grants, shared tools, event venues, playbooks, and more.

NoF is supported by a living directory-a shared library of people, tools, methods, needs, and capacities. This directory works as an infrastructure that makes collaboration easier. It helps actors find one another, make visible what they are already doing, and understand what others are offering or seeking.

Organisations are onboarded gradually and intentionally. One may be a place-based actor embedded in a specific neighborhood; another may be a thematic organisation with deep expertise in a domain like livelihoods, climate resilience, or education. Each new entrant is added through a trust-based invitation, with clear documentation of their asks and offers.

To support continuity, transparency and trust, NoF builds rhythm into the work. Monthly cadence calls with participating organisations become spaces to share updates, surface tensions, track progress, and identify opportunities for convergence. These are not reporting mechanisms- they allow members to be in conversation with each other, to see overlaps and gaps, and to slowly develop a shared memory of the place and its patterns.

## Community Owned and Owed to the Community

None of this is owned or operated by a single entity. Instead, different pieces are held by different organisations, based on capacity and intent. A rotating co-stewardship allows responsibilities to be shared and rebalanced as needed, ensuring that the structure remains responsive and not extractive.

Over time, a co-steering committee who offer backbone services -may emerge-formed by trusted partners who help anchor the effort. They will uphold standards of transparency, fidelity, guide learning, and support documentation. They will also help shape the initiative by guiding who joins, what values are upheld, and how progress is tracked. Services could take the form of convening forums, librarian services, community management and general 'follow upping'. To be sure, these continue to be carried out in the 'mahaul' of peer learning, where all members have visibility into ongoing efforts and are encouraged to join in.

We see NoF as a space to be inventive and to experiment with new modes of collaboration- fractional hiring, co-owned infrastructure, peer learning systems, and small, place-sensitive nudges. The goal is not to centralize delivery, but to decentralize possibility.

## The Asks and Offers Process

We will operate on the well-worn lesson that meaningful collaboration begins with clarity- about what each organisation brings, and what it needs. Participation in the project is by invitation, rooted in trust. We reach out to organisations that are willing to engage relationally over time.

Each participating organisation is asked to define two things:

1. **What can you offer?**
   Offers may include physical spaces (like schools or community centres), thematic tools (such as facilitation guides or curriculum), financial resources (grants or program funding), or social capital (access to citizen networks or local champions). These offerings are not abstract-they are assets that can be layered into existing or new efforts in a geography. Many of these get activated at shared points of delivery-like Learning Experience Centres or place-based interventions.

2. **What do you need?**
   The asks are often specific: local partners to support implementation, facilitation support to adapt a model, access to new communities, or small grants to

prototype an idea. These help us understand not just what an organisation wants to do, but what would make it easier or faster for them to do it well.

All asks and offers are documented in a growing directory and revisited through regular cadence calls. This living knowledge base enables better pairing, planning, and progress tracking. It also lowers the coordination cost of working together by making mutual value visible.

## Frictions we need to solve

Perhaps the most important and least visible aspect of the NoF structure is alignment. Not just in terms of shared values or vision, but in the actual mechanics of collaboration. Alignment is what allows diverse actors to move in coordinated ways without being identical.

- Who gets visibility, and how do we honour contribution without creating competition?
- How do we ensure that interventions maintain their core integrity when adapted to new geographies or needs?
- How do we support meaningful collaboration without exhausting already stretched teams?
- Who ensures coherence and integrity across the whole effort?
- How Do Communities Hold NoF Actors Accountable?

# TLDR: Reframing the Gap

Most frameworks start by identifying what's missing- what people don't have, what services aren't present. We could instead begin by asking: *What do people already know, care about, and offer?* What existing relationships, skills, and resources already anchor the neighborhood- and how can institutions build with, rather than for, communities?

This shift moves us from a model of provision to one of participation.

NoF should ideally help many kinds of actors come together and build something larger than the sum of their parts. We see it as a deliberately loose structure built on trust and transparency, that enables collaboration, discovery, and alignment across organisations rooted in different geographies and domains.

Most importantly, places benefit. The neighborhood becomes a more vibrant, responsive space- receiving useful services, new ways of working, and a deeper sense of shared possibility.